

Rainbow's End

..A NOVEL.

BY REX BEACH

Author of
"The Iron Trail," "The Spoilers,"
"Heart of the Sunset," etc.

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Nothing but a heap of stones and plaster remained of the Varona home. The grounds, once beautiful even when neglected as in Donna Isabel's time, were now a scene of total desolation. A few orange trees, to be sure, remained standing, and although they were cool and green to look at, they carried no fruit and the odor of their blooms was a trial and a mockery to the hungry visitor. The evidences of Cueto's vandalism affected O'Reilly deeply; they brought him memories more painful than he had anticipated. Although the place was well-nigh unrecognizable, nevertheless it cried aloud of Rosa, and the unhappy lover could barely control the emotions it awakened. It was indeed a morbid impulse which had brought him thither, but now that he was here he could not leave. Unconsciously his feet turned toward the ancient quarry which had formed the sunken garden—his and Rosa's trysting place.

O'Reilly desired above all things to be alone at this moment, and so he was annoyed to discover that another person was before him—a woman, evidently some miserable pacifico like himself. She, too, appeared to be looking for roots, and he almost stumbled over her as he brushed through the guava bushes fringing the depression.

His sudden appearance alarmed the creature and she struggled, panic-stricken, out of his path. Her rage could not conceal the fact that she was deformed, that her back was crooked, so he muttered a reassuring word to her.

This place was more as he had left it—there was the stone bench where he had said good-by to Rosa; yonder was the well.

"Senor!" Johnnie heard himself addressed by the hunchbacked woman. Her voice was thin, tremulous, eager,



A Woman, Evidently Some Miserable Pacifico Like Himself.

but his thoughts were busy and he paid no heed. "Senor! Do you look for something—some one?"

"No, no. Yes—" he answered, abstractedly. "Yes, I am looking for something—some one."

"Something you have lost?"

"Something I have lost!" The question came to him faintly, but it was in tune with his unhappy mood that it affected him strangely. He found that his eyes were blurring and that an aching lump had risen into his throat. This was the breaking point.

O'Reilly's hearing, too, was going wrong, for he imagined that some one whispered his name. God! This place was not dead—it was alive—terribly alive with memories, voices, a presence unseen yet real. He laid hold of the nearest bush to steady himself, he closed his eyes, only to hear his name spoken louder.

"O'Reilly!"

Johnnie brushed the tears from his lashes. He turned, he listened, but there was no one to be seen, no one, that is, except the dusky cripple, who had straightened herself and was facing him, poised uncertainly. He looked at her a second time, then the world began to spin dizzily and he groped his way toward her. He peered again, closer, for everything before his eyes was swimming.

The woman was thin—little more than a skeleton—and so frail that the wind appeared to sway her, but her face, uplifted to the sun, was glorified. O'Reilly stood rooted, staring at her until she opened her eyes, then he voiced a great cry:

"Rosa!" What more he said he never knew.

He took the misshapen figure into his arms, he rained kisses upon the pinched, discolored face. But Rosa did not respond; her puny strength had flown and she lay inert in his embrace, scarcely breathing.

Dazed, doubting, astounded, it was some time before Johnnie could convince himself of the reality of this moment, and even then words did not come to him, for his mind was in turmoil. Joy, thanksgiving, compassion—a thousand emotions—mingled in a sort of delirium, too wild for coherent thought or speech.

rear finally brought him to his senses, for he became aware that Rosa had collapsed and that his endearments left her unthrilled. Quickly he bore her to the bench and laid her upon it. After a time she smiled up into his eyes and her words were scarcely more than a murmur:

"God heard my prayers and sent you to me."

"Rosa! You are ill, you are weak—" Her eyelids fluttered. "I am dying, O'Reilly. I only waited to see you."

"No, no!" In agony he gathered her once more into his arms.

"Oh, yes!" Her bloodless fingers touched his face again, then his thin, worn lips. "You, too, have suffered. How came you to be so poor and hungry, O'Reilly?"

"I'm not poor, I'm rich. See?" He fished the coins in his pocket. "That's money; money for you, sweetheart. It will buy you food and medicine. It will make you strong again, Rosa, dear. I have looked for you so long, so long—" His voice broke wretchedly and he bowed his head. "I—I was afraid—"

"I waited as long as I had strength to wait," she told him. "It is too bad you came so late."

Once again she lapsed into the lethargy of utter weakness, whereupon he fell to stroking her hands, calling upon her to come back to him. He was beside himself now; a terrible feeling of impotence and despair overcame him.

Hearing someone speak, he raised his eyes and discovered at his side that figure of want which he had seen digging on the slope below. It was Evangelina. The negroess was little more than skin and bones, her eyes were bleared and yellow and sunken, her face had grown apellike, but he recognized her and she him.

"You are the American," she declared. "You are Rosa's man."

"Yes, but what is wrong with her? Look! She is ill—"

"She is often like that. It is the hunger. We have nothing to eat, senor. I, too, am ill—dying; and Asensio—Oh, you don't know how they have made us suffer."

"We must get Rosa home. Where do you live?"

Evangelina turned her death's head toward the sky. "Down yonder. But what's the use? There is no food in our house and Rosa is afraid of the corpses. You know—the ones with the worms. She bade me bring her here to die."

The girl was not wholly unconscious; she stirred and murmured faintly: "Those wagons! Don't let them put me in there with the other dead. They pile the bodies high—" A weak shudder convulsed her.

O'Reilly bent lower, and in a strong, determined voice cried: "You are not going to die. I have money for food. Rouse yourself, Rosa, rouse yourself."

"She prayed for you every night," the negroess volunteered. "Such faith! Such trust! She never doubted that you would come and find her. Sometimes she cried, but that was because of her brother. Esteban, you know, is dead. Yes, dead, like all the rest."

"Esteban is not dead," O'Reilly asserted. "He is alive. Rosa, do you

hear that? Esteban is alive and well. I left him with Gomez in the Orient. I have come to take you to him!"

"Esteban alive? Ha! You are fooling us." Evangelina wagged her head wisely. "We know better than that."

"I tell you he is alive," O'Reilly insisted. He heard Jacket calling to him at that moment, so he halted to the boy, then when the latter had arrived, he explained briefly, without allowing Jacket time in which to express his amazement:

"Our search is over; we have found them. But they won't believe that Esteban is alive. Tell them the truth."

"Yes, he is alive. We found him rotting in a prison and we rescued him," Jacket corroborated. He stared curiously at the recumbent figure on the bench, then at O'Reilly. He puckered his lips and gave vent to a low whistle of amazement. "So, this is your pretty one, eh? I—She—Well, I don't think much of her. But then, you are not so handsome yourself, are you?"

Evangelina seemed to be stupid, a trifle touched, perhaps, from suffering, for she laid a skinny claw upon O'Reilly's shoulder and warned him earnestly: "Look out for Cobo. You have heard about him, eh? Well, he is the cause of all our misery. He hunted us from place to place, and it was for him that I put that hump on my back. Understand me, she is straight—straight and pretty enough for any American. Her skin is like milk, too, and her hair—she used to put flowers in it for you, and then we would play games. But you never came. You will make allowances for her looks, will you not?"

"Poor Rosa! You two poor creatures!" O'Reilly choked; he hid his face upon his sweetheart's breast.

Rosa responded; her fingers caressed him and she sighed contentedly.

O'Reilly's ascent of the hill had been slow, but his descent was infinitely

slower, for Rosa was so tremulous that she could help herself but little and he lacked the strength to carry her far at a time. Finally, however, they reached the wretched hovel where Asensio lay, then leaving her there, Johnnie sped on alone into the city. He returned soon with several small bundles concealed about his person, and with Evangelina's help he set about preparing food.

Neither Rosa nor the two negroes had any appetite—their hunger had long since passed the point at which they were conscious of it—and O'Reilly was compelled to force them to eat. When he had given them all that he dared he offered what food was left to Jacket.

The boy moistened his lips and his fingers twitched, but he shook his head. "Oh, I'm not so hungry," he declared, indifferently. "I have a friend in the market place; I will go down there and steal a fish from him."

O'Reilly patting him on the shoulder, saying: "You are a good kid, and you should, don't you? These sick people need more food than we can buy for them, so we will have to draw our belts tight."

"Of course, eating is a habit, anyhow, and we men know how to get along without it. I will manage to find something for you and me, for I'm a prodigious thief. I can steal the hair from a man's head when I try." With a nod he set off to find his benefactor's supper.

CHAPTER XVIII.

The Haunted Garden.

Rosa Varona did not die. On the contrary, under her lover's care she made so amazingly swift a recovery that improvement was visible from hour to hour; she rallied like a wilted flower under a refreshing rain. It was O'Reilly's presence as much as the nourishing diet provided by his money which effected this marvel, although the certainty that Esteban was alive and safe put added force into her determination to live. Rosa found hope springing up in her breast and one day she caught herself laughing. The marvel of it was unbelievable. O'Reilly was sitting beside her bed of leaves at the time; impulsively she pressed his hands to her lips.

"Such happiness as mine belongs in heaven," she managed to tell him. "Sometimes it frightens me. With you by my side this prison is a paradise and I want for nothing. War, suffering, distress—I can't imagine they longer exist."

"Nevertheless, they do, and Matanzas is anything but a paradise," said he. "We must set about quickly to get out of it."

"Escape, you mean? But that is impossible. Asensio can tell you all about that. The Spaniards used to issue passes for the men to go outside the lines in search of food. It was just a trick. They never came back—all of them were killed. Everyone knows better than to try now."

"Nevertheless, we can't stay here much longer." In answer to the girl's puzzled inquiry he explained: "My money is gone—all but a few cents. This is the last of our food and there is no chance of getting more. Jacket has some mysterious source of supply and he manages to bring in something every now and then, but there are five of us to feed, and he can't furnish more than enough for himself. No, we must make a move at once, while we have the strength."

Rosa had not asked the source whence came the blessed food which was bringing the life blood back into her body, and although that food was not much—a little meal, a plantain, an occasional scrap of meat or fish—it had never occurred to her that the supply might be limited. She met the problem bravely, however.

"I have been close to death so long that it means little to me," she confessed. "I have you, and—well, with you at my side I can face the worst."

"Oh, we won't give up until we have to," he assured her. "If I had money it would be a simple proposition to bribe some guard to pass us through the lines, but I have spent all that General Betancourt gave me." He smoothed back Rosa's dark hair and smiled reassuringly at her. "Well, I'll manage somehow; so don't worry your pretty head. I'll find the price, if I have to waylay old Don Mario and rob him. Don't you think I look like a bandit? The very sight of me would terrify that fat rascal."

"To me you are beautiful," breathed the girl. Then she lowered her eyes. "La, la! How I spoil you! I have quite forgotten how to be ladylike. Isabel was right when she called me a bold and forward hussy. Now, then, please turn your face aside, for I wish to think, and so long as you look at me I cannot—I make love to you brazenly. See! Now, then, that is much better. I shall hold your hand, so. When I kiss it you may look at me again, for a moment." Drawing herself closer to O'Reilly, Rosa began thoughtfully: "Before you came I more than once was on the point of appealing to some of my former friends, but they are all Spaniards and we are no longer—slipshod, you understand?"

Rosa paused for his answer.

"Perfectly; I'm in the same fix. Of all the people I used to know there isn't one but would denounce me if I made myself known. Now that I've been fighting with the insurgents, I haven't even gone to the American consul for help—if there is an American consul."

Rosa nodded, then continued, hesitatingly: "I had a vivid dream last night. Perhaps it was a portent. Who knows? It was about that stepmother of mine. You remember how she met her death? I wrote you—"

"Yes, and Esteban also told me."

"It was he who recovered her body from the well. One day, while we were in hiding, away up yonder in the Yumuri, he showed me an old coin—"

"I know," O'Reilly said quickly. "He told me the whole story. He thinks that doubloon is a clue to your father's fortune, but—I can't put much faith in it. In fact, I didn't believe until this moment that there was a doubloon at all."

"Oh, indeed there was! I saw it."

There was a moment of silence during which the lovers were oblivious to all but each other, then Rosa murmured: "How strange! Sometimes your eyes are blue and sometimes gray. Does that mean that your love, too,

"Certainly not. But come, what about Esteban and that doubloon?"

With an effort the girl brought herself back to earth. "Well, it occurred to me, in the light of that dream last night, that Esteban may have been right. Of course nobody outside of our family credits the old story, and yet my father was considered a very rich man at one time. Pancho Cueto believed in the existence of the treasure, and he was in a position to know."

"True! Perhaps, after all—" O'Reilly frowned meditatively.

Rosa lifted herself upon her elbow, her eyes sparkling. "Wouldn't it be wonderful if it were true? Just think, O'Reilly, cases of Spanish gold, silver coins in casks, packages of gems. Oh, I've heard Isabel talk about it often."

(Continued in next issue.)

HIGHER STANDARDS IN STUDIES MAKES SCHOOL WORK HARDER

SALEM, Aug. 27.—Because of a higher and more difficult standard in the course of study for Oregon high schools, established by State Superintendent J. A. Churchill, all students, except an occasional pupil who is more than ordinarily mentally and physically strong, will be required to spend four years in completing the course. The maximum number of subjects allowed is placed at five and only students of more than average strength and ability will be allowed to carry that number through any school year.

The new course has just been issued by Churchill. A complete revision of the course has been made necessary because of the change in text-books made by the state textbook commission in June. The complete course manual contains 116 pages and the course embraces all subjects given in any standard high school.

Superintendent Churchill's statement says:

Hereafter American history and civics will be compulsory. Each student will also be required to study English throughout the high school course. Fifteen credits are required for graduation. No student may carry more than five subjects, and the teacher is cautioned not to permit any one to carry five subjects, excepting a student of more than average strength and ability.

In the preparation of the new manual, I secured the assistance of a group of experts in the various special subjects. Acknowledgment is made to the following persons: Edwin T. Reed, Oregon Agricultural college; Dr. A. P. McKinlay, Lincoln high school, Portland; Miss Edna Sterling, Salem high school; for the preparation of the course in English; Henry M. DuBois, LaGrange high school, for the courses in science; Miss Irene Mate Campbell, Jefferson high school, Portland; for the course in Latin; Miss Jessie Cox, Salem high school, for the course in history; Frank H. Shepherd, Oregon Agricultural college, for the course in manual training; Miss Bertha Davis, Oregon Agricultural college, for the courses in home economics, and Dr. Timothy Cloran, University of Oregon, for courses in Spanish and French.

The course in English is more extensive and complete than any course heretofore published in an Oregon manual, and conforms to the report of the committee on English representing the National Education association. Eight terms of one-half year each are offered. While the work in composition is emphasized, much space is given to the study of good literature, to the end that the student may be inspired to read intelligently, pleasantly and widely. Detailed suggestions are given the teacher for presenting poetry, drama and the novel.

In languages, four years of Latin, French and Spanish are offered; four years of science and of history are outlined. Full and complete courses in industrial and commercial subjects have been prepared. Much freedom in the choice of elective studies is given, with the hope that a student will not be forced to take a subject in which he is not interested and for which he has no aptitude.

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25,000 Population In 1925

It is presumed that with the coming of September the Live Wires of the Commercial Club will resume their get together meetings.

This organization has done much to help solve the problems of the city from time to time and have an enviable list of achievements to the credit of their organization. With reconstruction plans facing every section, manufacturing plants seeking locations in every part of the west, with a sure increase in population, it will be an easy matter for Oregon City to attain a population of 25,000 within the coming five years. If Oregon City at the present had 300 vacant houses they would be filled in less than 30 days. It will be the serious business of the Live Wires to look after the coming of new industries, and devise a plan to house those who are anxious to make this their home.

LIEUTENANT TOOZE TO DISCUSS LEAGUE OF NATIONS SATURDAY

Lieutenant Lamar Tooze, just back from two years of interesting experience overseas in France, will give his lecture at the Congregational church on Saturday evening at 8 o'clock, in furtherance of the campaign to raise funds for the Women's Building at the University of Oregon. A charge of 50 cents and 25 cents, according to seats taken, will be made. All of this money will go towards the building.

On writing Mrs. George T. Gerlinger of Dallas about the proposal that he give these lectures, Lieut. Tooze wrote the following:

"I plan to give an intimate story of a soldier's impressions and experiences of the war, and will also deal with the League of Nations, military preparedness and related subjects. You may want to know my attitude on the League of Nations: I feel that the principle is fine, but that the league is still in its infancy and must be developed before it can be very effective. We should encourage it and at the same time should not overlook its shortcomings. In other words, we should expect not too much of it now, but on the other hand, we should not discard the principle as certain Senators now advocate."

"I was in Paris for four months and made a positive effort to ascertain the international opinion on the League and feel that I am familiar with the obstacles which confront its operation."

Lamar Tooze was the representative of the University of Oregon student body upon the Ford Peace fiasco and gained much interesting and humorous experience while on this trip overseas. Among the gifts given Mr. Henry Ford upon the occasion of his departure in his ship for the North Sea was a caged squirrel. This squirrel was immediately adopted by the New York World as its correspondent and what was reported by the World to be wireless messages from its squirrel correspondent told of how the squirrel saw nuts everywhere but did not have a nut to eat and therefore was starved to death. The humor of the situation greatly impressed Lieut. Tooze on this trip, but he gained much useful knowledge of world wide affairs.

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